

Chapter 17-1

The rich fragrance continuously permeated the air.

With every breath, her nostrils were filled with this scent.

Liang Shi's lower abdomen was taut, and her arm brushed against Xu Qingzhu's skin.

It carried a slight coolness.

But this coolness couldn't dissolve the burning heat in one's body at all.

Liang Shi turned her face away slightly and also shifted her body toward the other side of the bed.

The hottest spot was her shoulder.

It seemed as if hot tears had fallen onto it, soaking through her T-shirt.

That patch of skin on her shoulder was burning intensely.

She must have encountered something troubling, Liang Shi thought.

But Liang Shi didn't ask.

She didn't know if Xu Qingzhu, like herself, preferred not to have people speak in such an atmosphere.

She only needed a shoulder to lean on, to absorb some energy.

Even just a little bit would do.

If Xu Qingzhu wanted to talk, she would naturally speak.

If she didn't want to, Liang Shi would simply be her reliable support.

Fortunately, Xu Qingzhu didn't stay long.

She leaned for a while, then withdrew. In the darkness, Liang Shi could vaguely make out her silhouette.

She sat up, supporting herself on the bed with both arms, her back facing Liang Shi, her face turned toward the window. In that instant, Liang Shi felt she looked very lonely.

It was the same kind of loneliness as her own.

But it was only for a moment. Xu Qingzhu bent down to put on her shoes, stood up and picked up her phone. Her voice had already returned to its cool tone, though if you listened carefully, you could still tell she had been crying.

"I'll leave first," Xu Qingzhu said.

Liang Shi also sat up. "Don't you plan to say anything?"

Xu Qingzhu's footsteps paused. "What would you like to hear?"

"Didn't you say earlier that you wanted to chat?" Liang Shi asked.

Xu Qingzhu shook her head. "I don't want to anymore."

Liang Shi: "....."

She was quite capricious indeed.

But it was rather interesting.

Liang Shi had thought Xu Qingzhu would be the type who was introverted, cool, gentle, and reserved, but she hadn't expected that getting to know her would be so surprising.

She wasn't rigidly intelligent, nor was it a deliberately crafted persona.

She just appeared quiet, gentle, and aloof on the surface, but actually had a heart that was both fiery and resilient.

Very much like... a wolf in sheep's clothing¹.

Also very much like... a master of deception².

Liang Shi responded indifferently: "Oh."

She didn't force it either, and lay back down on the bed. Xu Qingzhu walked to the door and stopped again, calling out in a low voice: "Liang Shi."

"Mm?" Liang Shi responded with a nasal sound.

"You owe me a favor, right?" Xu Qingzhu said.

Liang Shi: ".....?"

"Tonight," Xu Qingzhu reminded her. "Zhou Yi'an has always been hiding her gender from the public."

"Then how did you know?" Liang Shi asked.

"I have a friend who treated her."

"Is it Zhao Xuning?"

Xu Qingzhu paused. "That has nothing to do with you."

"Then why did you tell me?" Liang Shi stood up, approaching step by step. "Simply to help me?"

"What do you think?"

"I think it's not." Liang Shi moved closer to her, able to smell the light fragrance from her hair. "You've always wanted to divorce me. If I got together with Zhou Yi'an, then you would get your wish, but you didn't do that. Given how much you dislike me, I wouldn't simply believe that you told me this out of concern for me, so... what's your purpose? Or rather, what else do you want to get from me?"

She was very close, almost pressed against Xu Qingzhu as she said these words.

Her lips were just a tiny bit away from Xu Qingzhu's ear.

Xu Qingzhu didn't move at all.

Hearing this, she laughed softly, then restrained her smile. "Regardless of the purpose, the fact that I helped you is true, right? So you owe me a favor."

"Then what do you want me to do?" Liang Shi asked. "Does the Xu family company still need financing? You heard my phone call just now, didn't you? Right now the Liang family can barely protect itself and needs to sell off their daughter to obtain a piece of land. I probably can't help you."

"I haven't thought of it yet," Xu Qingzhu said. "When I think of something, I'll have you repay it. No need to rush."

"Xu Qingzhu." Liang Shi stepped back half a step. "You're completely different from before now."

She stated this fact in a calm tone.

Xu Qingzhu suddenly turned around, a smile playing at the corner of her mouth. "Then isn't there a possibility that you've never truly understood me?"

Liang Shi was momentarily speechless.

"You should rest," Xu Qingzhu said and left the hospital room.

Liang Shi stood in place, only coming back to her senses when she heard the door close.

Footnotes:

¹ Wolf in sheep's clothing (白切黑): A Chinese internet term describing someone who appears innocent and harmless on the surface but is actually cunning or dark-hearted underneath.

² Master of deception (扮豬吃老虎): A Chinese idiom literally meaning "pretending to be a pig to eat the tiger," referring to someone who deliberately appears weak or foolish to deceive others and gain an advantage.

Chapter 17-2

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Xu Qingzhu, who had walked out of the hospital room, hurried toward the elevator. This was the busiest time at the hospital.

The elevator entrance was crowded with people, and she stood among the crowd, trying her best to conceal herself.

The composure she had just forced made her face flush with heat. Her face and ears were bright red, her palms had broken out in a layer of sweat, making her phone damp and hot in her grip.

There were five fingernail marks in her palm where she had dug her nails in forcefully, and her nail beds showed an abnormal whiteness.

An auntie beside her asked with concern: "Young lady, are you alright? Do you need me to call a doctor for you?"

"No need, thank you, auntie." Xu Qingzhu politely declined.

She placed her hand over her heart, forcefully trying to calm her wildly beating heart.

She wasn't an actress after all—her acting skills were too clumsy.

If the lights had been on, Liang Shi would definitely have noticed her abnormality.

Fortunately, with the lights off, she could force herself to put on an act.

The elevator rose to the tenth floor. When Xu Qingzhu returned to her hospital room, a young nurse was hanging an IV drip. Hearing footsteps, she turned around and greeted her with a smile: "You're back."

"Mm." Xu Qingzhu sat on the bed and took several deep breaths before she somewhat recovered.

"Lie down," the young nurse said. "The sooner you finish the IV, the sooner you can sleep."

"Alright." Xu Qingzhu placed her phone on the bedside table and asked while the young nurse was inserting the needle: "Where is Dr. Zhao?"

"Making rounds," the young nurse replied. "There's a patient who needs an examination. It'll probably be a while before she's done."

"I see."

"Do you need her for something?" the young nurse asked.

"Mm, I'll call her later. Thank you," Xu Qingzhu said.

After the young nurse finished setting up the IV and left, the hospital room became quiet, and Xu Qingzhu finally completely relaxed.

A clear tear fell.

She raised the back of her hand to wipe it away.

Her phone vibrated soon after.

She reluctantly picked it up—it was a message from her mother.

【My precious Bamboo¹.】

Before Xu Qingzhu could reply, messages quickly flooded the screen.

【Your father said if it's not possible, then forget it. Don't let these things cause friction between you and Ah Shi.】

【Your father and I discussed it. Minghui² was destined for this fate. We've tried our best—there's nothing we can do about it.】

【None of this has anything to do with you. Today mommy was too emotional, so I put pressure on you.】

【I'm sorry, mommy apologizes to you. As long as you're well, that's enough. You don't need to worry about family matters. Your father and I have been through everything—this small matter won't defeat us.】

【Mommy only has you and your sister now. I'm really sorry—we shouldn't have transferred this pressure to you.】

【My precious Bamboo, mommy loves you.】

As Xu Qingzhu read these messages, her eyes reddened.

She wiped away the tears that fell again and tapped the screen to reply: 【I asked Liang Shi. The Liang family can't provide us with assistance.】

This time her mother sent a voice message: "It's okay, the Liang family has already helped us enough. Haven't you rested yet? Has your sister been giving you any trouble?"

Xu Qingzhu replied: 【Yaya has been quite well-behaved.】

She chatted with her mother for a while longer. Her mother desperately apologized to her and tried to comfort her emotions.

She also said that Minghui³ hadn't reached a dead end yet, and that her father could handle it.

Minghui Jewelry was a family business passed down from her great-grandfather, but her father really wasn't cut out for business.

The family business had begun to decline within just a few years of being passed to him.

Even though they had just received thirty million yuan in financing a few months ago, they still couldn't escape the fate of bankruptcy.

Xu Qingzhu thought for a moment and sent a message to her father: 【I plan to join the company.】

Footnotes:

¹ Bamboo (竹子): This is an affectionate nickname based on Xu Qingzhu's name, where "zhu" means bamboo. Chinese parents often use elements from their children's names as nicknames.

² Minghui (明輝): This refers to Minghui Jewelry, the Xu family's company name.

³ Minghui: Referring again to the family jewelry business that has been struggling financially.